

ance between the two.

From an economic perspective, India will continue to grow at 8 to 9 per cent per year; but this growth will be sustained only if the bottom of the pyramid is able to pull itself up to a growth of above 4 per cent. The inter-linkage between higher economic growth leading to enhanced demand for agricultural products and a higher agricultural growth triggering additional demand for goods and services from the industrial, manufacturing and services sector needs to be understood. This will enable us as policymakers to give the much-needed impetus to the agriculture sector.

BHARAT SINGH

Minister of Panchayati Raj, Rajasthan

The state of Rajasthan occupies the top slot in rapeseed and mustard production. These crops require little rainfall and are ideally suited for a dry and arid state like Rajasthan. But unfortunately, in the last so many years, our production of mustard is very low in comparison to other countries because no new variety of mustard has been developed. Why have our scientists failed? Why are our 'model farms', which should have pioneered new varieties of crops, not able to produce these? Had this been achieved, our farmers could have produced a better yield.

RAVI S SAHNI / www.indiatodayimages.com



On the nutrition front, it is a matter of deep concern that 45 per cent of our children still suffer from malnutrition. While ensuring availability and access to adequate food, we must also ensure that the nutritional requirement of the citizens, especially of children and women are addressed. Providing adequate amount of pulses, vegetables and dairy products in addition to cereals is imperative if we aim to remove the blot of malnutrition from our nation. Mid-day meals, Integrated Child Development Services schemes, Public Distribution Schemes, etc address this need to a great extent but the failure to produce enough food will greatly impair their utility in the days to come. We must also recognise our constraints in realising these policy imperatives. We will have to produce more per square inch of land and per drop of water to fulfil the growing requirements of our vast population.

Given the land and water constraints, and the target of growth, both in quantitative and financial terms, the only option that we have is to shift Indian agriculture from its present level of technology, knowledge and management to a higher level on all three counts. The second Green Revolution, in my view, may not follow the path of the first Green Revolution. While frontier technology will have to play a predominant role, much more attention will also need to be paid to the management of water, sustainability of resources, avoidance of waste, better management of farms and processing of agricultural produce. Similarly, regional disparities in production across various states in the country will need to be addressed. In a country as vast as ours, the dependency on seven or eight states to feed the nation is not prudent. For instance, this year and even last year, we have had record production of wheat and rice and also record procurement of these two grains. Though we are facing a severe drought, our comparative position of the stocks is much better and we are not depending on imports, particularly for wheat and rice. There are hardly three or four states—Punjab, Haryana, Uttar Pradesh—which have taken to producing wheat in a major way. Practically about 85-90 per cent procurement of wheat is from these states. And the situation in terms of rice is no different. About 80-85 per cent rice has been produced and procured essentially from Punjab, Haryana and Chhattisgarh. Fortunately, in rice production West Bengal is improving and so is Orissa. Ultimately, these six